

Housewives of the era seemed to be in solid agreement: they loved the trading stamp programs. In a Stanford Research Institute study of the Denver area in the early 1950s, almost two out of three shoppers believed that stamps meant they were getting something for nothing. Customers reported an “inner satisfaction” from using stamps and a “feeling of thriftiness” from redeeming the completed books. Hmm, those comments sound vaguely familiar.

By 1963, figures from a poll conducted by Benson & Benson, Inc. showed that 84 percent of households were saving stamps. Just as with coupons today, statistics showed that it was those from the middle and higher income brackets and the better educated who were the most likely to save trading stamps.

Trading stamps have gone the way of the dinosaur for the most part, with their large-scale demise during the 1970s gas shortages. Will coupons do the same? Are those of us who avidly use coupons wasting our time? Is extreme couponing nothing more than an obsession with getting something free?

Are extreme couponers crazy? Or, crazy like a fox? Let’s look at the foibles and lifestyles of some of the extreme couponers, and you can decide for yourself.